

The Emacs Series

Exploring dash.el

dash.el is a list library for Emacs released under the GNU General Public License v3.0. It has been written by Magnar Sveen and the latest release is v2.15.0. The source code is available at <https://github.com/magnars/dash.el>. In this first part of the series of articles on dash.el, we will explore functions on map transformations, sublist selection, list operations and reductions.



Before going into any details about dash.el, let's first get the installation done.

Installation

The dash.el package is available in Milkypostman's Emacs Lisp Package Archive (MELPA) and in the Marmalede repo. You can install the package using the following command in GNU Emacs:

```
M-x package-install dash
```

If you want the function combinators, then you should also install the following:

```
M-x package-install dash-functional
```

The other method of installation is to copy the dash.el source file to your Emacs load path and use it.

In order to get syntax highlighting of dash functions in Emacs buffers, you can add the following to your Emacs initialisation settings:

```
(eval-after-load 'dash '(dash-enable-font-lock))
```

Usage

The API functions available in dash.el are prefixed with a dash ('-'). Let us first explore the map transformation functions on lists.

Maps

The '-map' function applies a given function to each element in a list. In the following example, the 'square' function squares each element in the list:

```
(-map function list) ;; Syntax
```

```
(defun square (n) (* n n))
```